

■ POETRY ■

Miriam Manglani

**OUR DEAD REFUGEE DADS**

Our fathers were refugees  
who came to America  
with only a few dollars in their pockets.  
Mine from Egypt, his from Pakistan.

We laugh at the similarities,  
their hording of money—  
mine hid diamonds  
under floor boards in the attic,  
because you never know  
when you're going to need a diamond, right?

The refusal to spend hard earned money,  
replace ancient things  
bleeding, worn to the bone—  
chair with springs popping out,  
frayed comforter with holes,  
rusty car spewing black smoke.

Two sides of the same coin,  
both collected—  
some kept in fancy sleeves,  
others sparking around the house  
like everyday loose change.

The collecting of office supplies  
as if they were gold.  
Pens, pencils, markers,  
paper too—  
primary colored, pastel, construction,  
my color blind father had it all.

Both shied away from close relationships—  
the trauma still in them,  
a river running through their veins.

I wonder if they are together now,  
smiling from above at their children  
when we put money in the bank,  
talking about their shared experiences  
and what it was like to keep running.